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Moral Outrage and Cancel Culture in the Digital Age

- A Qualitative Study of Generation Z

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Abstract

Background: Cancel culture involves withdrawing support from public figures or brands due to perceived wrongdoing and is often driven by social justice concerns. Central to this phenomenon is moral outrage, emotional reactions like anger and disgust, now rapidly expressed and amplified through social media, intensifying public accountability. Existing research has mainly focused on the outcomes of cancel culture, and limited research has explored the emotional and behavioural factors behind it. This thesis addresses this gap in marketing literature by examining how moral outrage shapes consumer responses to perceived moral violations. By integrating the concept of moral outrage from sociology into marketing literature, the thesis provides new insights into this gap in consumer behavior and the influence of moral outrage in the dynamics of cancel culture.

Purpose: This thesis aims to explore the influence of moral outrage within cancel culture from a consumer perspective, addressing the research gap by combining empirical findings and theoretical insights to enhance academic understanding and guide future marketing practices.

Method: This study employed a qualitative research design developed within the interpretivist paradigm to explore how moral outrage influences cancel culture. An abductive research approach was adopted, allowing for iterative movement between existing theories and empirical data. Data were collected through two semi-structured online focus groups, each comprising six Generation Z participants. A thematic analysis was conducted to identify latent patterns and underlying values in participants' responses, with codes developed collaboratively by the three authors.

Conclusion: The results deepen understanding of moral outrage in cancel culture by revealing how social influence, performativity, and digital environments shape reactions. By examining Generation Z's perspectives, this study offers a clearer, consumer-based understanding of how moral outrage operates and contributes to existing literature by highlighting how moral values are shaped and amplified by social media environments.

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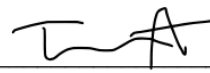
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1. Introduction

This chapter introduces the research topic, highlighting the key concepts of cancel culture and moral outrage. It provides background information on these concepts, highlighting their significance in today's digital and social landscape. The chapter further identifies the research gap in current literature and introduces the research question guiding this study.

1.1 Background

Matilda Djerf; a Swedish influencer and founder of the brand Djerf Avenue, built on the value terms kindness, inspiration, and respect (Djerf Avenue, n.d.), was in 2024 called out for creating a workspace “far from the polished facade” (“*Anställda larmar om ”psykisk terror” på Matilda Djerfs företag*”, 2024). Aftonbladet, a Swedish news outlet, was the first to release a mini-documentary in which 11 people who are now or have previously worked for Djerf Avenue came forward with testimonies about how people were afraid of Matilda because of her volatile temper and ability to scream at her employees and call them names. In the weeks following the release of the documentary, several international news outlets reported on the drama (Savin, 2024; Hewson, 2024; Acheson, 2024). Djerf lost 200,000 followers (Hawken, 2024) and faced an intense backlash on her social media; she had come face-to-face with cancel culture.

From initially emerging as a buzzword, cancel culture has evolved into an established and powerful social phenomenon. Cancel culture is defined as the withdrawal of any form of support (viewership, social media follows, or product purchases) from brands, public figures, or organizations perceived to have engaged in unacceptable or highly problematic behavior (Tandoc et al., 2022; Ng, 2020). Cancel culture is generally rooted in a social justice perspective and often linked to issues such as sexism, heterosexism, homophobia, racism, and bullying (Ng, 2020). Its origins can be traced back to 2015 when it first emerged among African American Twitter users as a form of activism against individuals or brands making racist remarks (Tandoc et al., 2022). Ng (2020) argues that it gained momentum during the #MeToo movement when several public figures were publicly called out for inappropriate behavior and judged in the “social justice court.” Opinions on cancel culture remain divided; while some

view it as a powerful tool for amplifying consumer concerns that might otherwise go unheard, others argue that it can do more harm than good (Diether et al., 2024).

Moral outrage is described as the composition of emotions such as anger, contempt, and disgust, which fuels a desire for punishment and revenge in the pursuit of restoring justice (Abbasi et al., 2024; Brady et al., 2021; Coombs & Tachkova, 2023). Moral outrage has existed for as long as civilization itself. However, with the rapidly changing world and advancement of technology, the ways in which moral outrage is expressed and spread have evolved significantly, becoming faster, reaching wider audiences, and increasingly impacting companies through digital platforms (Crockett, 2017). The evolution of technology enables the expression of moral outrage online without restrictions of location, time, or the risk of direct confrontation (Brady et al., 2023; Crockett, 2017). Additionally, research indicates that individuals are now more likely to be informed and influenced by moral violations encountered through online platforms than through traditional media (Crockett, 2017; Rathje et al., 2023). Studies have further shown that the expression of anger fuels more anger. Social media's capability of facilitating the expression of outrage can lead to further intensity of outrage in the future (Crockett, 2017).

1.2 Problem Discussion & Research Gap

In the age of digital media, expressions of moral judgment have become increasingly visible and amplified. Social media platforms like Twitter, TikTok, and Instagram enable real-time responses to perceived moral violations, often escalating into viral calls for accountability or punishment, a phenomenon widely referred to as cancel culture (Tandoc et al., 2022). Existing literature tends to focus more on the outcomes or societal impacts of cancel culture rather than investigating the influence of moral and emotional aspects. From sociology literature, this research borrows the concept moral outrage, defined as the composition of emotions such as anger, contempt, and disgust, which fuels a desire for punishment and revenge in the pursuit of restoring justice (Abbasi et al., 2024; Brady et al., 2021; Coombs & Tachkova, 2023). This concept will be examined in relation to cancel culture, drawing from marketing literature, to contribute to existing literature by providing a deeper understanding of how emotional and behavioral reactions influence the cancel culture dynamics.

Moral outrage is often assumed to lead to action. However, Mihailov et al. (2023) point out that it remains unclear whether online expressions of outrage lead to collective behavior, such

as boycotts or coordinated public shaming, highlighting the need for future research. Cancel culture provides a particularly relevant setting in which online moral outrage appears to translate into collective behavior, however, this assumed link remains insufficiently tested. A study by Cummings et al. (2025) proposes that there could be additional predictors, such as personal values, cultural influences, and the effects of digital echo chambers, that may play significant roles in shaping canceling behavior. While Cummings et al. (2025) hypothesize potential structural and sociocultural influences, they remain underexamined, indicating a gap in existing literature. In addition, there is limited understanding of the emotional mechanisms, particularly moral outrage, that may influence these factors. Despite cancel culture being rooted in response to perceived moral violations (Costa & Azevedo, 2023; Kyriakou et al., 2023), its connection to moral outrage as a driver of cancel culture behavior has not been sufficiently studied, leaving a need for further research.

Furthermore, Crockett (2017) argues that digital environments may intensify these emotional responses and potentially transform the nature of moral outrage itself, for example by making it more reactive, performative, or habitual. However, Crockett (2017) underlines the need for further empirical studies by highlighting a gap in whether this transformation influences social behaviors. Building on this gap, cancel culture, a collective social phenomenon that primarily exists online (Zhang et al., 2023; Saldanha et al., 2022), emerges as relevant for investigating the transformation of moral outrage in digital environments.

Together, these research gaps, borrowing the sociology concept of moral outrage into the marketing literature, highlight the need for deeper research into how moral outrage functions not just as an emotional response but as a social and behavioral influence within cancel culture. Understanding the influence of moral outrage in this context is essential for both academics and marketers to gain deeper insights and understanding into consumer behavior in today's digital landscape.

1.3 Purpose

This thesis aims to investigate how moral outrage influences the dynamics of cancel culture from a consumer perspective, filling the research gap through empirical and theoretical analysis to provide theoretical contributions and practical insights for academics and marketers.

1.4 Research Question

Based on the presented research gap, this study will be guided by the following research question:

How does moral outrage influence the dynamics of cancel culture?

2. Literature Review

This section reviews existing literature on moral outrage, cancel culture, brand hate, and social media, providing a theoretical foundation for the study. It outlines the method used to gather and analyze relevant academic sources, ensuring a comprehensive understanding of the topic.

2.1 Method for Literature Review

The literature review was conducted to develop a comprehensive understanding of the topic and to explore the concepts in existing academic literature. Finding relevant sources constitutes just one aspect of performing a literature review; another is filtering out irrelevant sources (Snyder, 2019). To guide the search, specific keywords were used, including “cancel culture”, “social media”, “brand hate”, “moral outrage”, and “eWOM”, as well as different combinations of these keywords using “AND” in order to refine our results. The search provided results where the keywords could be found within “all fields” to avoid missing out on important literature.

To further maintain the relevance and quality of the sources, articles that were published within the last 15 years and listed in the ABS list (Academic Journal Guide) were included. These were accessed through the database Scopus, to maintain the high-quality academic sources. After carefully reviewing the ABS-listed articles, an ancestry search was implemented. During

an ancestry search, references of key articles were traced for the purpose of gaining a comprehensive understanding of the subject, helping researchers to understand the broader context (Bodolica & Spraggon, 2018). The final number of articles used in the literature review was 44.

2.2 Cancel Culture Overview

Tandoc et al. (2022) define cancel culture as “the withdrawal of any form of support (viewership, social media follows, or product purchases) from brands, public figures, or organizations perceived to have engaged in unacceptable or highly problematic behavior”. Cancel culture emerged from African American users on Twitter (Diether et al., 2024; Tandoc et al., 2022), and this new type of negative brand relationship has become an increasingly pervasive phenomenon in the digital age (Zhang et al., 2023). Cancel culture was initially designed to highlight the wrongdoings of influential figures and foster solidarity in addressing social injustices collectively (Diether et al., 2024; Tandoc et al., 2022), for instance, racism, sexism, and bullying (Ng, 2020). Saldanha et al. (2022) back up the explanation of the phenomenon's emergence and origin from African American users on Twitter and further explain that cancel culture grew bigger during the social justice movement #MeToo.

Although cancel culture reflects earlier concepts such as calling out, online shaming (Tandoc et al., 2022), brand boycotts, and brand retaliation, (Costa & Azevedo, 2023), it distinguishes itself by primarily happening across social media platforms, and its rapid spread allows it to reach a large audience in a short amount of time (Zhang et al., 2023; Saldanha et al., 2022). Social media platforms enable quick information sharing and public opinion mobilization, facilitating participation in social movements for a wide audience and for collective actions such as cancel culture to gain momentum (Velasco, 2020; Picarella, 2024; Jusay et al., 2022).

A “cancellation” typically begins when an individual or brand engages in behavior that conflicts with the audience’s values or morals (Zhang et al., 2023). Tandoc et al. (2022) explain various motivations behind the decision to cancel an individual or a brand. Participation in cancel culture is often driven by ideological incompatibilities, where consumers react negatively to certain issues, including racism, ethnocentrism, environmental concerns (such as greenwashing), animal rights, sociopolitical issues, and labor issues (Costa & Azevedo, 2023; Kyriakou et al., 2023). This often sparks a negative social media post where someone exposes perceived misconduct. From there, a chain reaction of collective actions follows, including

posting negative comments on the individual's or brand's social media pages, unfollowing their social media accounts, engaging in boycotts, and amplifying the information across various social platforms through negative word-of-mouth (WOM) (Zhang et al., 2023; Kyriakou et al., 2023; Roldan et al., 2024). These actions seek to prevent the canceled individual or brand from continuing harmful behavior or promoting an unacceptable viewpoint, criticize them, remove them from the public spotlight, or offer a sense of fulfillment by advocating for what is perceived as morally just (Tandoc et al., 2022).

The ultimate goal of cancelling an individual or a brand is rarely to permanently remove them or destroy them, but to call for change and accountability. When an apology is offered and perceived as genuine by the recipient, it is likely to reduce the desire to cancel and enhance loyalty towards the individual or brand (Costa & Azevedo, 2023). Opponents to cancel culture argue that there is a risk for cancel culture to escalate into cyberbullying and unjust punishment, beyond the original intent to create social justice (Diether et al., 2024; Kyriakou et al., 2023). Furthermore, it is argued that cancel culture may become disproportionate, with similar penalties being applied to a wide range of perceived offenses, regardless of their severity (Ng, 2020). Part of the reason why cancel culture prompts individuals to act more aggressively online than they would offline may be that individuals can anonymously express hateful opinions without having to face the real-world consequences (Cook et al., 2021; Kucuk, 2019; Kyriakou et al., 2023).

Brand Hate in Cancel Culture

Humans tend to recall negative events more easily than positive ones, which can be considered negativity bias. Literature has previously focused much on positive emotions but prefers to ignore the unpleasant, yet very important, emotion of hate (Kucuk, 2019). Hate is generally not defined as a primary emotion, such as anger or joy, but rather as a complex emotion involving several primary and/or secondary emotions (Kucuk, 2019; Zarantonello et al., 2016). However, it is unclear, or less explored, which specific emotions constitute hate. According to Kucuk (2019), disgust and irritation are two out of at least fifty emotions that can be directly associated with the word hate.

Feeling brand hate differs from just disliking a brand; it involves deeper and more intensely held emotions, as mentioned above. Brand hate also differs from the more commonly understood concept of interpersonal hate (Hegner et al., 2017; Kucuk, 2019). However,

research shows that people attribute human characteristics to brands and, therefore, share feelings and emotions with brands in the same way they do with friends. This suggests that humans experience emotions, both positive and negative, in ways mirroring those in interpersonal connections (Fournier & Alvarez, 2013).

According to Rasouli et al. (2024), consumers seeking to manage feelings of brand hate are likely to adopt various response strategies, where the authors explain two types of strategies, “attack-like” or “avoidance-like”. Zarantonello et al. (2016) further propose a third sort of strategy, “approach-like”. “Approach-like” and “attack-like” can be categorized as *Active brand hate*, constituting emotions including anger and disgust, while “avoidance-like” is rather a *Passive brand hate*, constituting emotions related to fear and despair (Bayarassou et al., 2020; Rasouli et al., 2024; Zarantonello et al., 2016).

The first strategy, attack-like, often stems from a strong and profound feeling of betrayal by the brand (Bayarassou et al., 2020) following corporate wrongdoing, which can be behaviors the consumer perceives as unethical (Zarantonello et al., 2016). It is likely to result in aggressive actions such as engagement in negative WOM, protests, and boycotts (Rahimah et al., 2022). In extreme cases, consumers may engage in actions to actively harm the reputation and operations of the brand perceived as doing corporate wrongdoing (Sameeni et al., 2023).

The second strategy, constituting *Active brand hate*, approach-like, is likely the result of a violation of expectation or a genuine desire for the company to change its practices or policies. The actions taken can be to complain directly to the brand to express dissatisfaction or to protest against the brand (Zarantonello et al., 2016).

Lastly, the avoidance-like strategy is mostly the result of a dislike for the products or services of the brand because of personal preferences or a negative experience with the brand's offerings (Roy et al., 2022). The corresponding action is to stop purchasing from the brand or quit using the brand's services and switch to a different brand (Zarantonello et al., 2016). Previous studies thereby suggest that avoidance-like strategies are often not the result of unethical behavior but rather product-related issues (Hegner et al., 2017; Valenzuela et al., 2021).

Furthermore, consumers who admire and trust a brand are more likely to respond with intense negative emotions, such as anger and hatred, when the brand engages in wrongdoing (Costa &

Azevedo, 2023). Kucuk (2019) additionally suggests that the stronger the previous relationship with the brand, the more severe the criticism is likely to be, and the greater the likelihood that consumers will engage in anti-branding behaviors. Conversely, brands that are not held to such high standards may experience less severe backlash, as initial consumer expectations are lower (Costa & Azevedo, 2023).

As previously said, brand cancellation can be driven by ideological differences between the brand and its consumers (Costa & Azevedo, 2023; Kyriakou et al., 2023). This might occur, for instance, when the brand engages in a behavior that the customer believes to be unethical, leading to the consumers collectively withdrawing their support and participating in cancel culture (Saldanha et al., 2022). This causes the brand to trigger negative emotions in the consumer, which may result in the development of brand hate on an individual basis and trigger response strategies (Kurtoğlu et al., 2024). One can thereby view the collective movement of cancel culture as a catalyst for brand hate among consumers. Not all brand hate is triggered by cancel culture, and it is not limited to social media platforms (Hegner et al., 2017; Valenzuela et al., 2021; Zarantonello et al., 2016). However, current literature suggests that for the consumer to engage in cancel culture, the consumer has likely developed some level of brand hate (Zarantonello et al., 2016).

2.3 Moral Outrage

Humans are unique in their ability to speak up against injustice. The desire to observe, communicate, and cooperate, and consequently react badly when others violate norms and standards, is not a new concept; it is as old as civilization itself (Mihailov et al., 2023). Moral outrage refers to negative emotional reactions that arise when someone perceives a violation of moral principles, particularly the principles of justice and fairness (Abbasi et al., 2024; Brady et al., 2021; Crockett, 2017). The feelings composing moral outrage refer to emotions such as anger, contempt, and disgust and create a desire for punishment and revenge to restore justice (Abbasi et al., 2024; Brady et al., 2021; Coombs & Tachkova, 2023). Moral principles might be violated through incidents involving child labor, environmental harm, unfair treatment of customers or employees, or other unethical activities (Crockett, 2017).

The concept of moral outrage construct has three boundaries: (1) Harm is recognized when individuals perceive that moral rules or ideas of justice and fairness have been violated. (2) The actor causing harm did so on purpose, with the intention of violating moral norms. (3) The

harm has not directly affected the person observing the situation but rather a third party (Abbasi et al., 2024).

Evolution has enabled humans to speak up against cruelty and injustice, and third-party punishment is vital for human cooperation (Crockett, 2017; Mihailov et al., 2023). The high levels of cooperation among humans are directly correlated to the willingness to accuse and punish those violating the norms of cooperation, even when the individuals involved have no prior personal connection (Brady et al., 2021; Mihailov et al., 2023). Despite the personal risks and lack of benefits that come with standing up against someone acting in a way perceived as wrong, humans are unique in still choosing to stand up to enforce the moral norms (Mihailov et al., 2023; Simpson et al., 2017). Furthermore, social rewards and group norms can influence individuals' moral beliefs, meaning that the expression of individual moral outrage may not only be based on personal moral beliefs (Brady et al., 2021). However, research shows that seeing moral violations in day-to-day life is rare; fewer than 5% report witnessing an immoral act on a daily basis (Crockett, 2017).

Traditionally, moral outrage was expressed through personal interaction in the context of gossip, punishment, or shaming (Crockett, 2017). People tend to express outrage for the purpose of minimizing future violations from occurring or to encourage broader social justice (Brady et al., 2021). With the increase in usage and the development of digital platforms, the way moral outrage is expressed has changed (Crockett, 2017). Research shows that people are more likely to be influenced and informed of actions going against moral acts online rather than in traditional media (Crockett, 2017; Rathje et al., 2023). Expressing moral outrage online is not restricted by location, time, or the risk of direct confrontation. By using online platforms, people can express negative emotions that appear at any time or in any geographical location (Brady et al., 2023; Crockett, 2017). This can increase the promotion of social change and ethical norms, although the downside is harmful consequences such as online harassment and punishments (Crockett, 2017).

Brady et al. (2021) further suggest that social media platforms generate two different types of learning that influence how people express moral outrage online. The first process, reinforcement learning, means that people adjust their expression of outrage based on the feedback they receive, such as likes or comments. This can motivate people to continue to express moral outrage on digital platforms as they receive positive feedback. The second

process is normal learning. When people observe other members of their social group expressing moral outrage on digital platforms, they might follow the pattern by expressing their own negative emotions (Brady et al., 2021).

In addition to the psychological aspect, the online environment itself creates unique conditions for the expression of moral outrage online. The risk of confronting someone offline can enhance the risk of retaliation, compared to online where the backlash of expressing moral outrage is at a lower risk, as many people usually express negative emotions and experiences in forums or to people who already are feeling the same thing (Crockett, 2017; Mihailov et al., 2023). Expressing moral outrage online allows people to react and share their opinions and emotions instantly, without facing the consequences that typically come with face-to-face confrontation. Furthermore, the effort needed is minimal compared to traditional expressions of moral outrage, potentially making moral outrage more common online than offline (Crockett, 2017).

2.4 Social Media

The advancement of the internet and social media has created new options for users, in addition to making it easier to find information and communicate, social media further allows for the expression of emotions and ideas (Serrano-Puche, 2020; Tsimonis & Dimitriadis, 2014). The platform enables users to transform emotions into digital forms, which can be saved, stored, and compared, for example, messages or images (Serrano-Puche, 2020).

Tsimonis & Dimitriadis (2014) describe how, as social media becomes more popular, many companies are using it as part of their marketing and branding efforts. Social media offers businesses a chance to connect with customers using different types of media to reach more audiences. For brands, social media can have an essential role in monitoring and collecting customers' opinions, ideas, and impressions (Castillo et al., 2021), these insights can now be obtained from customers more rapidly than in the past (Hudson et al., 2014). These interactive platforms enable businesses to exchange information with customers while also facilitating communication among them. This transition allows companies to move beyond simple customer conversations to more complex interactions, where both customer-to-customer and customer-to-business communication occur (Tsimonis & Dimitriadis, 2014). Social media has allowed users to share information and voice their opinions to a broad audience. This means

that individuals can no longer only receive information but actively share it, potentially influencing how others perceive a product or brand (Soltani et al., 2023).

Furthermore, social media functions as a giant, rapid version of traditional word-of-mouth communication (WOM) (Tsimonis & Dimitriadis, 2014), and with the development of the internet, a new concept of WOM has arisen, electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) (Ngo et al., 2024). eWOM information describes any type of review or viewpoint of a good or service that is easily available to numerous people on online platforms (Le et al., 2024). eWOM differs from traditional WOM in that it allows for the quick distribution of information via online communication channels that are always available and retrievable (Ngo et al., 2024). Furthermore, eWOM is not constrained to describing good characteristics, it may also be used to highlight negative aspects (Verma & Dewani, 2020). Tsugawa and Ohsaki (2015), and Soltani et al. (2023) further explain that reposts of negative messages are likely to occur more quickly and frequently than those of neutral or positive ones. According to Soltani et al. (2023), this negative or scandalous information may have a major impact on a brand's reputation.

For instance, on the social media platform Twitter (now formally known as X), it has been demonstrated that tweets featuring emotional language, hashtags, and URLs have a higher chance of being retweeted than those without. Social media users' actions are not always unbiased and valid, and it is expected that psychological and emotional variables will influence their choices (Tsugawa & Ohsaki, 2015). The concept of eWOM refers to consumers spreading their reviews and opinions about a product or brand on online platforms, leading it to have power in influencing how consumers choose when deciding between brands or purchasing a product (Le et al., 2024). On social media, eWOM content can take various forms, while certain posts generate moderate engagement, others go viral, rapidly spreading to a wider audience (Ngo et al., 2024).

Brands that do not align with social and ethical expectations can be subjected to cancel culture (Zhang et al., 2023), the online "firestorm" fueled by negative word-of-mouth (nWOM). This backlash has the potential to harm both the reputation of brands and public figures (Costa & Azevedo, 2023). Social media platforms enable the rapid spread of information (Soltani et al., 2023), while simultaneously facilitating the distribution of electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), which can quickly amplify negative opinions about brands or individuals (Ngo et al., 2024; Verma & Dewani, 2020). The exponential rise in social media usage has made digital platforms

the most accessible source for up-to-date news and global events (Alfred & Wong, 2022). Consequently, social justice issues, including the Black Lives Matter movement, have been widely spread through social networks (Seemiller & Grace, 2017). As public figures and brands face increasing criticism on these platforms, cancel culture has become a significant aspect of modern society. This phenomenon is fueled by the rapid and widespread circulation of information that users can easily share across various social media platforms (Zhang et al., 2023).

The relationship between the concepts of cancel culture, brand hate, moral outrage, and social media can be found in Figure 1: Preliminary theoretical framework.

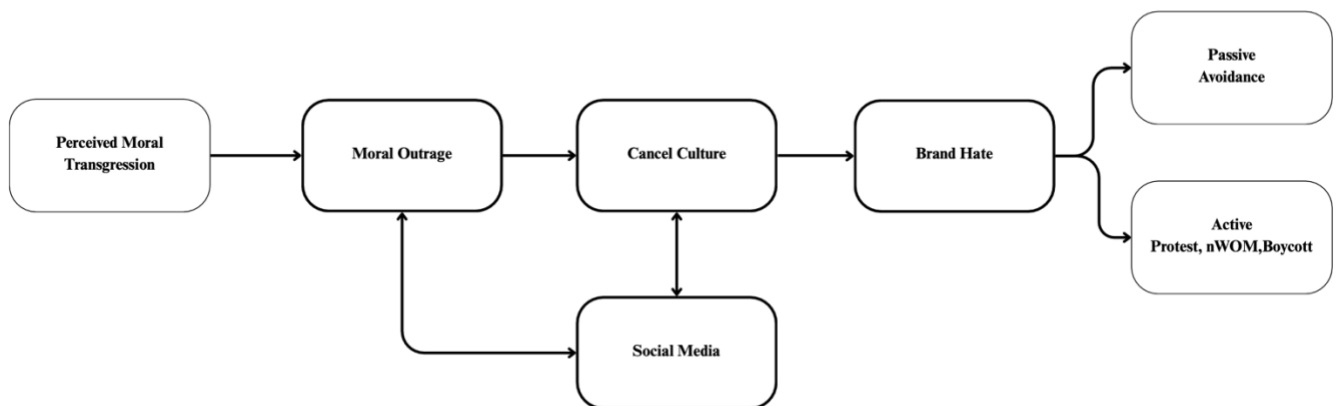


Figure 1: Preliminary theoretical framework (Source: The author's own work)

3. Methodology

This section of the research provides the choice of research philosophy, research approach, structure of the research design, including the sampling, data collection, and data analysis. Additionally, this section includes how the study ensured trustworthiness and ethical considerations research process.

3.1 Research Philosophy

Research philosophy defines the underlying principles and perspectives that shape how knowledge is developed, influencing the research process, data interpretation, and the perspective from which findings are analyzed (Saunders et al., 2023).

Interpretivism research aims to develop a new, deeper understanding and interpretation of social environments and settings. The interpretivism approach emphasizes that because people differ from physical phenomena, meaning is produced by humans and, therefore, needs to be explored differently. Furthermore, humans perceive and experience the world differently based on cultural background, distinct situational conditions, or social contexts. As a result, social reality varies from person to person, in contrast to universal law, which extends to all individuals (Saunders et al., 2023).

Given the qualitative nature of the study, interpretivism was considered the most suitable research philosophy for this thesis as it facilitates a comprehensive exploration of individual perspectives and collective discussions. This study focuses on cancel culture, a socially constructed phenomenon, driven by personal values that cannot be fully understood through objective measures alone, as underlying values, emotions, and moral reasoning may not be properly captured by such methods. This, in turn, makes it necessary to explore how individuals interpret these experiences individually. Because cancel culture is constantly changing based on social values, an interpretivist approach helps in understanding how individuals perceive and experience it in different contexts rather than assuming it has a fixed, universal meaning.

In contrast to the positivism paradigm, which emphasizes objective truth, interpretivism focuses on comprehending subjective meanings and the complexity of human behavior within various social circumstances (Saunders et al., 2023). By adopting a qualitative research

approach and utilizing focus groups, this study collects rich, contextually relevant data, allowing for a deeper understanding of how moral outrage among Generation Z influences the dynamics of cancel culture.

3.2 Research Approach

Saunders et al. (2023) discuss deductive, inductive, and abductive approaches as key considerations when determining the appropriate research approach for thesis writing. A deductive approach begins with an existing theoretical framework, often derived from academic literature, and applies it to new contexts to reach a logical conclusion, moving from theory to data. In contrast, an inductive approach starts with data collection to explore a phenomenon without investigating previous data, intending to generate or build a theory, and moving from data to theory (Saunders et al., 2023).

Due to the exploratory nature of this study, an abductive approach was deemed the most appropriate to examine the influence of moral outrage in the phenomenon of cancel culture among Generation Z consumers. An abductive approach integrates elements of both inductive and deductive approaches, allowing the iterative movement between theory and data. This process leverages the strengths of both inductive and deductive approaches while allowing for the discovery of new patterns and insights that existing theories may overlook (Saunders et al., 2023; Awuzie & McDermott, 2017). Through the integration of both empirical and theoretical knowledge, an abductive approach moves beyond established methods, enhancing the quality of outputs (Hurley et al., 2021).

By employing an abductive approach, this study began with pre-existing theoretical perspectives on cancel culture and moral outrage to gain a deeper understanding of these phenomena. As the research unfolded, empirical data from focus groups were continuously analyzed to identify inconsistencies, nuances, and new findings that existing theories may not fully explain. As new findings emerge from the data, they help refine and adjust existing theories, ensuring accuracy and relevance to the study. This iterative and flexible methodology connects theoretical and empirical findings through systematic combining, allowing them to interact and influence each other rather than being studied separately (Dubois & Gadde, 2002). Furthermore, this flexible method is particularly valuable for investigating cancel culture, a complex and evolving phenomenon where existing theories may not fully encompass the nuances of Generation Z consumers' perceptions and responses. Through this approach, the

study aims to contribute both to theory development and to a more nuanced understanding of how moral outrage influences the engagement in cancel culture.

3.3 Research Design

To address the research question, “*How does moral outrage influence the dynamics of cancel culture?*”, focus groups were selected as the primary research method to gain in-depth insights into how Generation Z consumers perceive and respond to cancel culture.

Focus groups are a qualitative research method involving structured discussions with a selected group of individuals aimed at gathering insights, opinions, and experiences related to a specific topic. This method is particularly well-suited for research seeking to explore multiple perspectives on the same issue (Gibbs, 1997). Considering the collective and emotionally charged nature of cancel culture, focus groups allow for the exploration of various opinions, values, and moral judgments by allowing for deep discussions and revealing emotional responses that may not arise through other research methods. The dynamic group interaction encourages participants to reflect on and respond to each other’s views, often leading to richer discussions and potentially give rise to new thoughts or forgotten experiences.

Compared to individual interviews, which focus on gathering insights from a single person's perspective, focus groups create space for a broader range of opinions and emotional responses through participant interaction. This group setting often leads to more spontaneous and dynamic conversations, as participants may take the initiative and lead the discussion in valuable directions. The social nature of the setting fosters openness and makes it more likely for thoughts, feelings, and experiences to emerge (Gibbs, 1997).

Although focus groups offer the advantage of capturing interactive and rich data from discussions, focus groups also bring some potential limitations that are important to acknowledge. For instance, group dynamics may lead to conformity in opinions or the influence of a dominant position (Whitehead & Whitehead, 2016). However, with careful moderation and thoughtful group composition, these challenges can be minimized to ensure truthful and valuable data.

3.3.1 Data Collection

Semi-structured interview questions were the selected research technique for this qualitative study. This method allowed for in-depth discussions to explore the unique emotions and reactions that arose among the participants regarding the topics of cancel culture and moral outrage, while also encouraging elaborate conversations. This approach provides a general structure for the interview, while also allowing for flexibility to ask follow-up questions to investigate new emerging topics during the discussions (Adeoye-Olatunde & Olenik, 2021). The focus group interview discussions were facilitated by one moderator, who asked 6 pre-planned, open-ended questions relevant to the studied phenomenon (*See Appendix A: Questions for Focus Group 1 & 2*), as well as relevant follow-up questions. The purpose of having only one moderator was to maintain structure and avoid confusion, while the other two researchers participated as active observers, taking notes throughout the discussions. Since all participants speak Swedish as their native language, the interviews were conducted in Swedish to enable them to communicate more freely and provide more detailed insights.

While the ideal number of participants in a focus group can vary depending on the study's objectives, a group size of 6 to 10 individuals is generally recommended to encourage rich, engaging discussions while remaining manageable (Gibbs, 1997). In this study, participants were divided into 2 online focus groups (OFGs), each consisting of 6 individuals. The discussions in each group lasted between 38-41 minutes. Conducted via Microsoft Teams, this format was chosen to enhance accessibility and allow broader participation. Smaller group sizes are particularly important in virtual settings, where managing group dynamics can be more challenging due to risks such as disorganization and overlapping dialogue (Falter et al., 2022). The chosen size enabled balanced, in-depth discussions, ensuring that all participants had adequate time to share and elaborate on their thoughts without frequent interruptions. Moreover, the use of OFGs provided greater flexibility, improved access for participants, and helped maintain engagement throughout the sessions.

The focus groups were structured by first showing three short videos featuring real-life scenarios involving the brands H&M, Balenciaga, and Djerf Avenue. Each video depicted a controversial situation that had contributed to the cancellation of the respective brand, highlighting ethical issues such as racism, discriminatory work environments, and inappropriate content involving children. These videos were carefully selected with the purpose of exemplifying real cases of brand controversies, directly aligning with the study's focus on

cancel culture and moral outrage. By showing these examples, the aim was both to ground the discussion in concrete, recognizable situations and to refresh participants' memories, encouraging deeper reflection and engagement.

3.3.2 Sampling

Selecting an appropriate sampling technique is crucial to effectively address the research question and objectives. Sampling techniques enable researchers to collect data more efficiently by selecting a representative subgroup of individuals relevant to the study rather than studying the entire population (Saunders et al., 2023). This procedure is highly important for increasing precision, decreasing errors and biases, and ensuring that the sample accurately reflects the key characteristics of the total population (Golzar et al., 2022).

In qualitative research, sampling is limited to non-probability sampling methods (Berndt, 2020). Given that this study involves focus groups, convenience sampling was identified as the most suitable non-probability sampling method. Convenience sampling involves selecting individuals who are most readily available and willing to participate in the study. It is widely used in qualitative research and is especially useful due to its time efficiency, cost-effectiveness, and ease of implementation (Stratton, 2021). This approach offers flexibility and simplicity, making it an efficient choice for the study.

This study targets Generation Z, commonly referred to as Gen Z, which includes individuals born between 1995 and 2010 (Narayanan, 2022; Sagar et al., 2025). This demographic was selected due to its unique historical and cultural upbringing. Gen Z is often considered the most digitally connected and tech-savvy generation due to their upbringing in a world driven by technology (Espejo et al., 2024; Ngo et al., 2024). They exhibit high levels of engagement on social media platforms (Espejo et al., 2024; Ngo et al., 2024), which serve as their primary means of communication (Alfred & Wong, 2022). Early awareness of global issues shaped their belief in personal power to drive change and influence corporations (Seemiller & Grace, 2017). Additionally, Mishra and Das (2024) mean that compared to previous generations, Gen Z places a strong emphasis on values such as transparency and honesty in the content they consume online. With their high levels of online engagement and active participation in discussions on trending topics, such as cancel culture, Gen Z represents a particularly relevant demographic for qualitative research on these phenomena. Table 1 contains a list of the focus group members.

Participant no.	Gender	Age	Date	Meeting Place
Participant 1	Female	22	8/4-2025	Teams
Participant 2	Female	26	8/4-2025	Teams
Participant 3	Female	23	8/4-2025	Teams
Participant 4	Female	23	8/4-2025	Teams
Participant 5	Male	23	8/4-2025	Teams
Participant 6	Male	23	8/4-2025	Teams
Participant 7	Female	24	10/4-2025	Teams
Participant 8	Female	23	10/4-2025	Teams
Participant 9	Female	23	10/4-2025	Teams
Participant 10	Female	26	10/4-2025	Teams
Participant 11	Male	23	10/4-2025	Teams
Participant 12	Male	24	10/4-2025	Teams

Table 1: Participants in the focus group

3.3.3 Data Analysis

A thematic analysis approach was used in this thesis to analyze the focus group data. The thematic analysis approach is used in a qualitative study to identify, analyze, and interpret a pattern of meaning in the data. This approach can identify themes at different levels, in this thesis, latent coding was adopted. A latent theme approach is chosen as it refers to exploring the participants' answers in relation to their assumptions, values, and social interpretation of the participants' meaning behind the words (Braun and Clarke, 2006).

The focus group sections were recorded and transcribed through Microsoft Teams' own functions. After the focus group sessions, the transcripts were carefully reviewed and adjusted to ensure they accurately reflected what had been said during the discussion. The transcript was read through again, and open coding was applied. Phrases that appeared to be significant were translated into English and converted into codes. According to Braun and Clarke (2006), codes stand for the smallest significant units of raw data that can be analyzed with regard to the

phenomena of the research. Following the coding process, the analysis continued by grouping codes into themes based on common patterns, topics, and shared underlying meanings identified in the participants' responses. Braun and Clarke (2006) further explain themes by analyzing the written codes into broader meanings, capturing the importance of concepts from the data, and providing insights into the study's research question. After the initial themes were developed, they were reviewed by reading through the transcript to ensure that each theme was consistent with the coded data. The themes were combined, removed, or refined to represent the participants' meanings correctly. Sequentially, the themes were combined into final themes, which represented the result from the data collection and were used to analyze in relation to the study's research question. This process is visually shown in the conceptual model (*See Appendix C: Thematic Analysis Process*) to provide the relationship between the themes found from the data collection. The conceptual model consists of 65 codes, 21 second-order themes, and 8 final themes.

3.4 Trustworthiness

The quality and credibility of qualitative research focus on providing reliable and accurate information that represents reality and how this information is conveyed and interpreted by the audience. The level of trustworthiness in qualitative studies is determined based on four criteria: credibility, dependability, transferability, and confirmability (Cope, 2014).

3.4.1 Credibility

Credibility in qualitative data refers to how believable and accurate the findings from the research are. It concerns whether the collected data truly reflect what the participants think, feel, or experience. Additionally, it refers to whether the material is presented and interpreted truthfully and fairly, without changing what the participants mean (Cope, 2014). Credibility in this study was strengthened by applying specific selection criteria in the literature review, including the use of up-to-date, relevant, and ABS-listed articles. This approach provided a comprehensive understanding of the phenomena of moral outrage, cancel culture, social media, and brand hate, and served to support and contextualize the study's findings. Additionally, to minimize the risk of misinterpretation, the analysis and interpretation of the focus group data were conducted collaboratively by three researchers and supported by thorough transcription. Anonymity was ensured for all participants, fostering open and honest discussions while safeguarding their confidentiality.

3.4.2 Dependability

In qualitative research, dependability refers to how consistent and reliable the data are when the research is repeated under similar conditions (Cope, 2014). Dependability was ensured by maintaining a clear and consistent methodology throughout the research process. Detailed documentation of the data collection, analysis, and decision-making procedures was kept to allow for replication under similar conditions. Additionally, the use of semi-structured focus group questions ensured consistency across discussions while also allowing flexibility for follow-up questions and clarifications. This approach, combined with a thorough description of the research process and methodology, enhances the study's dependability by making the research process transparent and potentially replicable. Furthermore, multiple researchers reviewed the research process to verify the consistency and stability of the findings.

3.4.3 Transferability

Transferability refers to how well a study's findings can be applied to other contexts, settings, or populations. In other words, it concerns whether the results have meaning and relevance beyond the specific participants involved in the study, allowing readers to relate the findings to their own experiences or environments (Cope, 2014). In this qualitative study, where focus groups were conducted with a total of 12 Gen Z participants, the ability to generalize the findings is limited due to the small and specific sample. However, to support transferability in this study, detailed descriptions of the data collection process and research context are provided, along with thoroughly transcribed focus group interviews and comprehensive coding of the data. This detailed information enables readers to assess whether the findings may apply to similar groups or settings, even if the scope of generalization remains narrow.

3.4.4 Confirmability

To ensure confirmability, the researcher must demonstrate that the findings accurately reflect the participants' responses, free from personal bias or subjective interpretation (Cope, 2014). Confirmability was ensured by maintaining transparency throughout the research process and grounding all interpretations in the participants' own responses. To minimize researcher bias, the analysis was conducted collaboratively by three researchers who discussed and reflected on the coding and interpretation of data. Additionally, direct quotes from participants are included in the findings section to illustrate and support each emerging theme, ensuring that the results are linked to the data collected.

3.5 Ethical Consideration

Ethical considerations are an essential part of conducting research involving human participants (Sim & Waterfield, 2019). This section outlines how ethical principles such as consent, confidentiality, and voluntary participation were upheld throughout the research process. According to Sim and Waterfield (2019), informed consent is only valid when four key elements are fulfilled: disclosure, comprehension, competence, and voluntariness. To ensure these principles were upheld, participants in this study were provided with clear and comprehensive information regarding the research's purpose, methodology, and potential risks before agreeing to participate. Additionally, participants were given the opportunity to ask questions and were encouraged to seek clarification if any aspect of the study was unclear. Participation was entirely voluntary, with no incentives or pressures to take part. Participants were reminded at every stage that they could withdraw from the study at any time, without consequences. To ensure confidentiality, anonymity was guaranteed for all participants, and all personal data was handled under the Swedish GDPR regulation (*See Appendix B: GDPR Form*).

4. Empirical Findings and Analysis

This section presents the empirical findings through the thematic analysis, highlighting key themes and supporting quotes from the participants. The final themes derived from the focus groups with Generation Z are explained and contextualized. Furthermore, the data is analyzed and interpreted with attention to both similarities and differences among participants, and comparisons are drawn to existing research to deepen the understanding of the results.

4.1 The Role of Social Media

Social media was seen as a major influence by the participants in terms of spreading news and information. Several participants emphasized how social media accelerates the dispersion of information, enabling news to reach a wide audience in a short amount of time. This was particularly emphasized by Participant 7, who noted that individuals often receive information through social media that they may not encounter otherwise. The speed at which information spreads on these platforms enables it to reach a larger audience and further amplify its impact.

"Maybe not that they really change, but that we get access to information through social media that we might not have gotten otherwise, which can help us make a decision. Everything really spreads faster and reaches more people. So I'd say it's kind of a helpful push in the right direction." - **Participant 7**

"Just in terms of information, like, I probably wouldn't have seen the Djerf Avenue stuff as quickly if my entire Instagram feed hadn't been flooded with it one morning. So we also inform each other, like "this isn't okay". Then it's up to us to take a stance, but at least we know about it." - **Participant 11**

Social media platforms, particularly TikTok, were consistently highlighted as the primary source for receiving information about company scandals, such as the Matilda Djerf incident. Participant 8, for example, described how the scandal flooded their TikTok feed, leading to widespread discussions, with many people declaring that they are going to stop shopping from the brand. Participant 12 further emphasized that social media also encourages collective action, as users encourage others to stop supporting brands they view negatively. Additionally, it was pointed out how social media allows individuals to quickly act against companies they perceive as unethical or problematic. Participant 10 highlighted that platforms like TikTok empower people to start a form of revolt against companies through the quick spread of information, potentially playing a big role in public opinion.

"That Matilda Djerf scandal again, like, it was all over TikTok and I read articles everywhere, and everyone was like, "Now I'm going to stop shopping. Now I'm going to stop shopping"." - **Participant 8**

"The scandals themselves might appear on social media. I mainly see them on TikTok." - **Participant 1**

"But social media kind of becomes, yeah, like you said, this thing where people are like "now we're going to stop shopping," and they actually encourage others not to buy from these brands." - **Participant 12**

"Especially with social media today, you can actually sort of start a bit of a revolt against companies you think are bad or that stand for the wrong things, and that's why I think social media plays a really big role." - Participant 10

"And like I mentioned earlier with Djerf Avenue, one day it was just endless scrolling and people were just cancel and cancel." - Participant 8

4.1.1 Analysis of The Role of Social Media

Participants emphasized the central role of social media in how Gen Z consumers access and circulate information, particularly in the context of brand-related controversies, such as the Matilda Djerf scandal. The speed at which information spreads and reaches large audiences was seen as pivotal to its impact, as it can bring attention to issues that might otherwise be disregarded or overlooked. This dynamic also amplifies the effects of electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), where several participants described how their social media feeds were flooded with negative content related to the Djerf scandal. These insights support findings from the literature review, where Soltani et al. (2023) highlight the powerful role of social media in the rapid dissemination of information, and Ngo et al.'s (2024) emphasis on how eWOM can intensify negative perceptions. Additionally, the discussions highlighted the role of collective action, as social media users were seen to encourage others to withdraw support from brands perceived negatively. This aligns with Costa and Azevedo's (2023) and Zhang et al.'s (2023) assertion that the spread of negative WOM and mass sharing of information can catalyze the emergence of cancel culture, simultaneously aligning with the definition of cancel culture according to Tandoc et al. (2022). Several participants recalled instances where they witnessed individuals actively promoting the cancellation of a company, reinforcing the idea that online discourse can trigger collective backlash and cancel culture.

Furthermore, as noted by Soltani et al. (2023), social media platforms enable users not only to receive information but also to actively disseminate it and express their opinions to a broad audience. This interactive environment of social media empowers individuals to influence others significantly through the content they share. The participants discussed this concept and supported it with empirical findings, which highlighted the significant role social media plays in influencing corporate decisions. Through social media platforms, individuals are empowered to challenge companies that are violating their moral values by starting a revolt, using their collective voices to pressure for change, and holding companies accountable for their actions.

Additionally, this aligns with Tandoc et al.'s (2022) assertion that such actions are driven by a desire to prevent the cancelled individual or brand from continuing their harmful behaviors and to advocate for what is perceived as morally just. Hence, social media plays a crucial role in cancel culture, as this platform enables individuals to collectively take a stand against corporate behavior that violates their moral values.

4.2 Expression of Emotions Online

Social media platforms such as X (formerly known as Twitter), Instagram, and TikTok were mentioned by several participants as being commonly used for expressing emotions. Comment sections are specifically mentioned as the place where the participant witnesses' others expressing negative emotions. Participant 5 shared that TikTok comment sections mainly consist of negativity, backed up by Participant 6's description of seeing people expressing hate on the social media platform X.

"If you think about TikTok comment sections, it's mostly just negativity you see, so the messages being shared aren't really positive." - **Participant 5**

"It feels like a lot of people hate on Twitter." - **Participant 6**

"I would say TikTok." - **Participant 4**

Emotions expressed on social media are seen as stronger and more open compared to regular face-to-face interactions. Participant 7 mentioned that people usually express much harsher emotions on social media compared to regular conversations. An example provided by Participant 1 is the scandal of Balenciaga, where the participant saw people's actions as a protest towards the company on the social platform TikTok. Furthermore, Participant 8 elaborates that emotions shared online may often be expressed to align with certain social trends. Emotional expression on social platforms can be a way for individuals to take a stand or show support. Participant 11 further highlights the problem of expressing negativity on social media, mentioning that in private settings, they are still active customers for the brand and do not express the same level of criticism. Social media may not change how people feel, however, Participant 10 describes that it can change how emotions are expressed.

"People are usually much harsher on social media, and it's very much like, 'I hate this brand, I'll never buy from them again,' and they tell everyone else like, 'This is absolutely awful.' But then, when you're actually talking in person, sure, they might still have that opinion, but it's not the same harsh tone that people often like to throw around on social media." - Participant 7

"Then I saw how people were breaking their Balenciaga glasses and throwing away their Balenciaga clothes, which doesn't help, but I guess it was some form of protest. And I saw all of that on TikTok." - Participant 1

"Sometimes people just want to follow the crowd and be kind of 'woke' and post everything. But then behind closed doors, like you said, they don't really care as much, it's more about taking a stand and showing that they're on the 'right' side on social media." - Participant 8

"Of course people should be able to express criticism, and maybe it's hard to actually change your buying habits, but at the same time, I think it's a bit hypocritical if you speak negatively, especially on social media, but then in more private settings you're not as critical and you keep being a customer. Then it almost feels like, okay, you just want to give the impression that you really care, but you're not really living up to it." - Participant 11

"I don't know if it really changes what you feel deep down, but it's at least what you express, I think." - Participant 10

Additionally, Participants 12 and 11 mentioned that they rarely share their emotions on social platforms. However, frustration and other emotions are more likely to be shared between friends or at other social gatherings. Participant 1 describes how discussions regarding a brand's actions typically take place in private conversations, such as on the social media platform Snapchat. Instead of expressing negative emotions online about the brand's actions, Participant 12 preferred to act by choosing not to purchase the brand's products.

"When it comes to, like, me and my friends, what we discuss, maybe it is on Snapchat, like 'have you seen this', that you write it to each other." - Participant 1

“I probably wouldn't speak out, it's more that I just wouldn't buy from them. But I would never post anything on social media or anything like that, you know, and it's hard to say.” -

Participant 12

“I probably wouldn't have expressed it on social media, but I definitely would have expressed some frustration when talking about it in conversations or similar situations.” -

Participant 11

4.2.1 Analysis of Expressions of Emotions Online

This theme emerges from the insights of Gen Z in the focus group, underscoring the powerful influence that social media has in the expression of emotions, aligning with existing research by both Serrano-Puche (2020) and Tsimonis & Dimitriadis (2014). As further explained by Soltani et al. (2023) and reflected in the findings, social media platforms have evolved to enable users to voice their opinions to a broad audience, particularly in comment sections. These expressions of emotions are mostly recognized as negative, aligning with the concept of moral outrage described by Crockett (2017). The participants experience that the expression of moral outrage online is perceived as more intense and harsher compared to face-to-face conversations. These findings are further supported by Crockett (2017), who indicates that compared to traditional ways, the effort and consequences of expressing negative emotions online, such as moral outrage, are lower. This helps explain why individuals may choose to express themselves online rather than offline. However, the empirical findings provide that while people observe others' moral outrage expression online, they are still more likely to adopt avoidance-like response strategies rather than engage in the expression of negative emotions online.

Furthermore, Gen Z discussed that social media does not change personal values, however, it can change how individuals express them, and that emotions expressed on social media can be expressed to align with current social trends. This supports Brady et al. (2021) research that social media can shape individuals' moral beliefs, demonstrating that the expression of moral outrage can be influenced by external factors. This indicates, by the participants' reflections, that moral expression or support is not only driven by personal beliefs, but it can also be influenced by social norms and others' collective emotional expression on social media platforms.

4.3 Social Influence and Moral Alignment

An important theme that emerged during the focus groups was the role of social influence and the respondents' perceived need to align morally with the group. Shame appeared as a recurring factor as participants expressed that feeling shame could result from supporting a brand that had been collectively condemned by the group. If social pressure had not been a factor, the participants would not have viewed the scandal as severe enough to stop supporting the brand. Participant 1 expressed that they would feel shame if they were to support one of the brands shown in the focus group and would therefore avoid telling others about their support for the brand. Participant 11 argued that it would be two-part, both the individual desire to stand behind the brands they use, but also not risk receiving critique from the group. Adding onto that, Participant 12 mentioned an example of a brand by a cancelled public figure, and further mentioned they would feel shame if supporting the brand.

“But also because, like I would, if I would buy from there now, I would be ashamed. Like. I would not be able to tell anyone because I would be ashamed.” - Participant 1

“There it becomes a lot of shame if you take another, like Paolo Roberto for example and his pasta, like, you are not super proud when walking around with that in your shopping cart” - Participant 12

“And that depends partly on my own values and that you want to be able to stand behind the brand you use, but also the social part that we mentioned earlier. Like, you don't want to get critique.” - Participant 11

Building on experiences of public shame, Participant 6 disclosed that their personal moral values did not prompt them to cease purchasing Marabou products when the brand got boycotted for continuing operations in Russia. However, when getting called out and questioned about purchasing by another customer during a grocery shopping occasion, it triggered a temporary shift in behavior. This behavioral change, however, regressed once the Participant was no longer under public observation, and they proceeded to purchase the product despite awareness of the boycott and associated moral criticism. This suggests that the shift in behavior was performative, to signal moral awareness to others rather than actual care for the boycott. The participant's experience exemplifies a pattern of public dissociation from the

brand's actions while continuing consumption in private, reflecting the influence of social pressure on consumer moral decision-making.

“Like when Marabou kept on selling their chocolate in Russia, then I didn't stop because of that. But then when someone came up to me at ICA like, “why would you buy this, like, you can't support them” then I didn't want to buy it anymore. But then I went and bought it anyway! Like after, because he didn't see, but I think it's a lot about like, yeah, the social pressure. I think that sets the base for it.” - Participant 6

Participant 1 reflected on possible reasons for the tendency to publicly display moral standpoints that may not be strongly held in private. Participant 1 states that people show public support to feel good about themselves, and that they want to show others that they agree on the issue, rather than genuine personal care.

“I think everyone wants to have this moral I'm talking about, and that when something gets on the news then you want to be like, you want to feel better or that you want to be like, yeah, like “I don't stand behind this” and then you talk about it because you want to be part of a solution” - Participant 1

“I think that everyone talks about it because you want to show that you agree about the issue and not because you actually care.” - Participant 1

Social media's potential to influence moral reasoning and the recognition of ethical boundaries further emerged as a topic of discussion, with participants offering a variety of perspectives. Participant 5 suggested that constant exposure to a range of different perspectives and negativity shared on social media might blur and negatively affect the individual's moral values and standpoints. Participant 12 argued that while core moral values might remain unchanged, social media provides increased access to information, allowing individuals to reflect on and critically evaluate existing beliefs. Participant 11 added that while the social pressure on social media might not change your opinions, you might feel that you want to align your moral values with those of the group. Expanding on that, the same participant observed that when engaging with like-minded people on social media, your values and opinions might get affected over time, as people tend to be more receptive to views that resonate with their own preexisting beliefs.

“Negatively. I think it (your values) gets exposed to more than it actually should by all negative comments and opinions and understandings” - Participant 5

“But I wouldn't say that your moral opinions change but rather that you get another perspective. More than actually changing your opinions and moral” - Participant 12

“I would not say that you get forced to have an opinion, but rather that it's easier to feel that “I also think so because everyone else think so”” - Participant 11

“I guess one follows people that has kind of the same values and stuff like you do yourself, and if they then start to express some kind of opinions, then you might have an easier time to identify, or so to speak sympathize, with those opinions and then it might affect your moral over time, or your values” - Participant 11

“I mean it forms what I think is good and bad in some way” - Participant 6

4.3.1 Analysis of Social Influence and Moral Alignment

A central finding from the focus group discussions was the role of social influence in shaping the Gen Z manifestation of moral outrage and behavior within cancel culture. During the conversation, participants shared that they avoided brands due to fear of social judgment and not necessarily due to their moral standpoint. That cancel culture is driven by collectivism, and a unified feeling of restoring justice aligns with Tandoc et al.'s (2022) description of cancel culture. However, the empirical findings can also expand upon the same description, that participation in cancel culture might also be a way to follow the crowd and conform to group identity.

The emotional driver of shame played a central role in the behavioral changes of the participants. This emotion emerges not necessarily from the act of supporting a controversial brand, but from the social consequences of being seen to support it. While the empirical findings reflect the broader aim of cancel culture and response strategies such as boycotts, where individuals are ashamed for supporting controversial companies to promote and restore social justice, it also highlights a novel aspect of how social surveillance and group expectations significantly shape moral outrage, and consequently, the manifestations.

Furthermore, social media was identified as a key platform for shaping and amplifying these moral norms. Participants described how exposure to others' opinions online influenced their sense of right and wrong, mirroring Kyriakou et al.'s (2023) findings that social platforms facilitate rapid ideological alignment, especially when engaging with like-minded users. However, this also raises concerns aligned with Diether et al. (2024) and Cook et al. (2021), who caution that cancel culture can spiral into exaggerated punishment or bullying, especially when moral outrage is more about conforming to a group than expressing deeply held values.

Overall, the empirical findings suggest that moral outrage in cancel culture often manifests as a form of social performance, heavily influenced by group norms, moral alignment, and digital visibility. While cancel culture may begin with a genuine call for accountability (Tandoc et al., 2022), the findings reveal that its practice among Gen Z participants often involves navigating the tension between personal beliefs and social approval and might be influenced more by conforming to group identity than earlier constructs of moral outrage and cancel culture suggest.

4.4 Moral Trade-off and Consumer Tension

The participants' opinions varied when they were asked to what extent their moral values impact their behavior toward a company. Participant 1 had strong opinions about two aspects that were the determining factor as to whether they would purchase from a brand: environment and labor conditions for the workers. Although Participant 12 went a bit more lenient, they still underlined that once the moral compass says to stop, that decision is final. The participants, who emphasized that they let their moral values take a rather big place in whether to purchase from a brand, were a minority among the participants.

“For me anyways it is really important with the environment and the workers, like slavery, child labor, and everything like that. When you can’t trust a company in those matters, I stay away.” - Participant 1

“It depends a lot, but one has some kind of moral compass and when that one says stop then I am very, it is pretty black or white. Either I shop or I don’t.” - Participant 12

For many participants, the decision seemed to be more complex when making a moral trade-off on how much place their moral values could take, or which moral values that were the most important. Participant 4 pinpointed it as a decision between which of the two would do less damage or feel less worse, rather than a decision between one good and one bad. Participant 3 mentioned it to be more part of a question of the drive to consume, clashing with the desire to act according to moral values, and Participant 4 further built on to that argument stating it might also be a question of economics and budget, how much one can let the “moral compass” take place.

“I would probably also say it is a bit the lesser of two evils (pest eller kolera) that like, [...] one has to choose your battles a bit what you care more about personally” - Participant 4

“So yes, even if I think that everything like that is super important, like, you are driven by buying things all the time and for it to be as cheap as possible and everything, and then you forget about it a bit and try to think about other things.” - Participant 3

“I think it depends on who you are as a person and like how good one has it economically. Like, how much the moral compass can take place?” - Participant 4

Furthermore, some participants weighed in on their previous expectations of the brand. If Participant 7, for example, felt that the betrayal of expectations was bigger, they would be more prone to stop purchasing from the brand, given that they expected more from the brand. On the other hand, when a brand had not marketed itself as being particularly focused on moral values, the sense of betrayal following a violation of those values felt less severe. As a result, participants were less inclined to withdraw their support or stop purchasing from the brand.

“I would not have purchased from them now, both because it's a brand that I get like...I expected more from them, if I can say so. Given that they market themselves other than how H&M does. And then I would have expected them having better policies, and like environment for the workers and everything” - Participant 7

However, it is important to highlight that some participants felt that it would take something relatively severe before they would stop purchasing and supporting a brand. While acknowledging the moral violation, Participant 8 would continue to support if the offered

products were desired enough. Participants 11 and 12 also spoke on the matter, and for them, it was both a question of the severity of the scandal, in addition to the cost of switching to another brand.

Of course it's serious stuff. Also the way she treats people, but it wouldn't stop me from, if I see a nice dress or top, I would have purchased from her anyways. - **Participant 8**

"It has to be pretty severe to stop purchasing from my point of view anyways" - **Participant 12**

"But it's also like you said before like: how easy is it to change, like, cause then you need to find a another product instead" - **Participant 11**

4.4.1 Analysis of Moral Trade-off and Consumer Tension

The findings among Gen Z suggest that moral outrage influences cancel culture in a conditional and context-dependent way rather than functioning as a universal trigger for consumer action. While a few participants demonstrated a strong alignment between personal moral values and consumption behavior, the majority revealed a more complex decision-making process. For many participants, moral considerations were weighed against convenience, economic constraints, emotional investment, and product desirability, leading to a spectrum of responses rather than a clear-cut boycott. This indicates that moral outrage may exist without necessarily resulting in cancel behavior, suggesting that its manifestation can range from private disapproval to public disengagement, or be absent altogether. Such findings align with the view presented by Tandoc et al. (2022) that cancel culture is characterized by varying degrees of withdrawal rather than a simple support-or-reject model.

Participants' references to how prior expectations of a brand contribute to the perception of moral violations and intensify feelings of betrayal align with the antecedents of brand hate outlined by Costa and Azevedo (2023). According to Costa and Azevedo's (2023) framework, when consumers experience a strong emotional connection to a brand or hold it to high moral standards, perceived violations of those expectations can generate an increased sense of betrayal. This increases the likelihood of negative reactions, including engagement in anti-branding behaviors. While the participants primarily described their personal responses in terms of withdrawing support, such as ceasing to purchase from the brand, these actions reflect

a form of symbolic disengagement that aligns with broader practices associated with brand hate and cancel culture.

At the same time, several participants described experiencing internal conflict, acknowledging a brand's moral failure yet continuing to support it due to practical or psychological trade-offs. This gap between moral recognition and action reflects broader dynamics, showing that moral violations do not uniformly result in outrage, but rather depend on perceived intensity and relevance. Although moral violations are observed, not everyone speaks up against them or cares enough to act to restore or preserve justice, the base for both moral outrage (Brady et al., 2021) and cancel culture (Tandoc et al., 2022).

4.5 Personal Responsibility and Response Strategies

Personal responsibility emerged as a recurring theme throughout the coding process, closely tied to participants' emphasis on individual accountability in shaping brand perceptions and responses during instances of company backlash. Participants expressed various perspectives on the extent of personal responsibilities one holds toward companies under public criticism. Long-term avoidance of companies was not a common response strategy, often due to a perceived lack of seriousness in the criticism, limited personal concern, or varying individual values and personalities. Participant 5 stated that a temporary break may be a more common response, but the lack of care restricted them from taking long-term distance.

“It's like you say, that one takes a temporary break, maybe, but maybe you don't care enough to actually do something long-term, to make a long-term decision for, or at least from my, that's how I think.” - Participant 5

“I haven't really taken such strong measures that I actually stay away from a company, a product, because of an incident over a long period of time. So I think it takes quite a lot, and maybe different personalities, for someone to be able to get to that point, maybe?” -

Participant 5

However, some participants see consumption from these companies as a form of support, suggesting that purchasing decisions are not only practical but simultaneously carry symbolic and moral weight. Participant 11 connected consumption with implicit approval of corporate behavior, suggesting that continued purchasing might signal an agreement with the company's

actions. Similarly, Participant 12 talked about how wearing or using a brand in public may be seen as showing support for it, and the importance of feeling that your values are aligned with the brand you consume. However, despite these acknowledgements, actual long-term disengagement from criticized companies was not frequent, with only Participants 1 and 11 stating they would cease to support a brand they do not like.

"It kind of suggests that, in a way, you're supporting their behavior if you buy their products."

- Participant 11

"Like, if you're going to walk around like a walking billboard and show off a brand, then you should probably be able to stand behind it too. That's how I feel, you know? I want to be able to stand by a brand that I'm out there representing." - **Participant 12**

"And then I guess I would change my purchasing behavior. And stop buying from companies I don't like at all." - **Participant 11**

"I haven't shopped from them before and I probably won't now either, but, that someone is a bad boss, well, there are a lot of bad bosses. So I think that... of course you shouldn't support a bad company. The money goes to her and she might be a bad person." - **Participant 1**

4.5.1 Analysis of Personal Responsibility and Response Strategies

In the context of personal responsibility and response strategies among Gen Z, insights from the focus groups revealed a range of reactions and reflections on how individuals respond to corporate wrongdoings. These varying responses align with the response strategies outlined by Rasouli et al. (2024) and Zarantonello et al. (2016): "attack-like," "approach-like," and "avoidance-like." As defined by Zarantonello et al. (2016), the "avoidance-like" strategy involves actions such as distancing oneself from the brand by ceasing purchases or switching to alternative brands. This pattern was reflected in the focus group data, where the findings revealed that temporary breaks in support or complete avoidance (avoidance-like) were the most commonly adopted strategy in response to brand hate among Gen Z consumers. This suggests that "attack-like" and "approach-like" strategies may be less frequently employed. However, a certain hesitance to completely cease purchasing from or supporting a brand, despite its violation of moral principles, was also revealed. Thus, the findings indicate that

avoidance-like strategies were the most common response to corporate wrongdoing among the participants.

This challenges Zarantonello et al.'s (2016) assertion that feelings of betrayal from corporate wrongdoing typically lead to attack-like strategies. Instead, the data revealed a stronger preference for avoidance over aggressive forms of retaliation. Furthermore, Rasouli et al. (2024) describes that individuals adopt various response strategies as a way to cope with feelings of brand hate. The empirical findings of this study may therefore indicate a relatively low level of brand hate among participants, as few of them engaged in any of the response strategies outlined in previous research. This suggests that individual reactions to corporate misconduct may vary depending on personal characteristics and underlying moral values.

4.6 The Dynamics of Cancel Culture

A few participants discussed that cancel culture is often inconsistent and unfair. Participant 10 highlighted the inconsistency and perceived fairness of cancel culture, where some individuals are being cancelled for their actions, while others are ignored for similar actions or even worse behaviors. This indicates a selective approach to cancel culture, where personal biases can be a critical aspect on who is faced with the risk and consequences of cancel culture.

“If we’re just speaking generally about cancel culture, it feels like a lot of people are like, “We don’t listen to, like, Swedish hip hop because they talk about gun violence and there’s a lot of violence and stuff,” and then there are a bunch of old guys in some hard rock band singing about all kinds of disgusting things, but no one cares.” - Participant 10

Participant 10 further reflected, with agreement from participants 11 and 12, on the importance of thinking more critically before acting and participating in cancel culture. As described by participant 12, brands or individuals are not judged the same way in every case, which indicates that cancel culture lacks consistency. The importance of being careful with what is expressed online is further highlighted by Participant 5, as public shaming or criticism can hurt public figures or brands. This indicates the participants' understanding that contributions to the social phenomenon cancel culture can lead to real consequences for the targeted person or brand.

So it's kind of like you can pick and choose what you want to feel, or how you want to direct it. So I think it's very... it's definitely not always fair or right, and I think it's important to really think twice before actually canceling someone. - **Participant 10**

"I agree. It's not exactly a court that judges the same way every time." - **Participant 12**

"So my conclusion is simply to be careful about what you say publicly, as it can harm other people, companies, and brands, and so on." - **Participant 5**

Participant 1 emphasized the important impact that collective action can have in shaping cancel culture. A group of people can have a significant effect that can result in a bigger impact compared to acting alone. Furthermore, Participant 11 highlighted that companies are aware of the cancel culture movement and the consequences that companies may face. This recognition of the consequences of collective actions should be carefully considered by companies before taking action to avoid being faced with potential negative outcomes based on their actions.

"Yes, I definitely think you can have a big impact if several people come together." - **Participant 1**

"Companies are aware of such movements and recognize the potential effects they can have. This should make them think two or three times before taking action." - **Participant 11**

4.6.1 Analysis of The Dynamics of Cancel Culture

Tandoc et al. (2022) describe cancel culture as individuals act in response to unacceptable or problematic behavior by a brand with withdrawal or support. The growing use of social media, combined with user anonymity, has made it easier for individuals to participate in the cancel culture movement. The focus group discussions provided a valuable perspective on how collective actions have a significant impact compared to acting alone. This is linked to the existing research by Saldanha et al. (2022) on the process of the cancel culture movement. When brands have violated moral values, consumers take collective actions on social media such as withdrawing support, engaging in boycotts, and spreading the information across various platforms.

Furthermore, the empirical findings align with the literature reviewed on the social phenomenon of cancel culture. Findings from the focus groups emphasize the aspect of cancel culture being unpredictable and disproportionate, which corresponds with the existing literature by Ng (2020). It was also highlighted in the findings from the focus groups that critical thinking is important before contributing to the cancellation of a brand. This is connected to Diether et al.'s (2024) and Kyriakou et al.'s (2023) statement that although the motivation to act against brands or individuals that have violated moral values is often grounded in the intention to create social justice, there is a risk that these actions lead to unjust punishment and cyberbullying. As further elaborated by Costa and Azevedo (2023), the ultimate intention of cancelling a brand or an individual is not to harm them or permanently remove them from the market, but instead to demand change and accountability. This reflects the complexity of cancel culture, where the intention is to create social justice, although the actions can instead lead to harmful consequences for the targeted party.

4.7 Company Accountability and Responsibility

Another key theme that emerged across the focus groups was the extent of company accountability and responsibility, and the role it plays in shaping a company's actions and reputation. This theme of accountability was closely tied to how companies handle their missteps. Several participants expressed that while mistakes can happen, what truly matters is the company's response and willingness to take responsibility. Participant 12 emphasized that the way a company reacts to a mistake is more important than the mistake itself, highlighting the value of transparency and accountability. Participant 11 backs this up by noting that poor handling of mistakes often intensifies public backlash, as it may signal a lack of awareness or responsibility. Additionally, Participant 6 agreed, mentioning that it matters more how the company handles the scandal or mistake than what it was about from the beginning, while emphasizing the importance of being honest and transparent in their actions.

“It’s really about how you handle it when you make a mistake, how you respond to it, and for me, that’s definitely much more important than the mistake itself was.” - Participant 12

“I think it’s especially poor handling that triggers more than the actual mistake, and the reason for that is that it suggests a deliberate action. It feels like someone has actually thought through a strategy and come up with something bad, and to me, that just seems irresponsible and foolish.” - Participant 11

“It is like, if they try to hide it. And it does not really matter what it is about I think. As long as they make up lies and it feels fake and everything, and if they come with an excuse that one feels is completely off” - Participant 6

The participants further elaborated on the importance of how the company handles and responds once a scandal has occurred, discussing whether the following response is perceived as authentic. Participants 1 and 3 expressed that the companies (shown in the introductory material of the focus group) only seemed to apologize as a “hail mary” to save the company, and not because the brand really acknowledged the mistake. Furthermore, Participant 1 elaborated on the matter that if the brand really cared, the scandal or mistake would not have happened from the very beginning.

“It is a lot like “if you have gotten offended by this I apologize, but we don’t think it was that wrong”, that it becomes the message, or like “we are just saying this to save our brand, but we might keep on making mistakes”, that you might not care about the people that has been offended and more about their company.” - Participant 3

“They are just apologizing now that they have gotten consequences for it. They did not really care. Otherwise they would not have done it from the start.” - Participant 1

However, taking responsibility and offering a sincere apology was not enough for all participants, as some participants believe that accountability should extend beyond apologies. Concrete efforts toward improvement, such as action plans for sustainability or equality, were seen as essential steps for regaining consumer trust. As Participant 1 mentioned, a clear path towards improvement helps signal that the company is committed to meaningful change, rather than simply reacting to public criticism.

“And maybe also having a plan to work towards improving, whether it’s sustainability, equality, or whatever the company’s shortcomings are, so that there’s clear progress.” - Participant 1

“Also, how companies choose to handle the situation matters. Like, if they take responsibility, apologize, and make sure that change happens, then I can feel like that’s okay, but still, it went wrong.” - Participant 11

Furthermore, the perception of negligence was particularly striking among participants, especially given that large corporations like H&M and Balenciaga typically undergo multiple layers of approval. As Participants 7, 8, and 11 noted, this should prompt more careful consideration before communicating messages to the public, raising expectations for thoughtful and responsible decision-making.

“It’s not certain that there was any bad intention behind it, but it’s really careless, and you could argue that big companies like that should think through these decisions one more time to avoid people getting upset by the messages they send.” - Participant 11

“Since these are such large companies, there must be many levels of approval and many people reviewing it. So, I think someone should have reacted before the public had to step in and say that it was wrong.” - Participant 7

“That it has gone through so many steps and still no one has had time to think about it? I don’t think a company would ever release something knowingly that they know will get a lot of backlash. It just shows that they didn’t think it through. But then, of course, it ends up going wrong.” - Participant 8

“Yeah, I think it’s pretty unprofessional not to have done some background research before going through with projects like this, which can be upsetting to a lot of people.” - Participant 5

4.7.1 Analysis of Company Responsibility & Accountability

The findings from the focus group interviews highlighted the significant importance Gen Z places on authenticity in apologies, transparency, honesty, and company accountability. These insights align with Mishra and Das’s (2024) claim that this demographic places a high value on transparency and honesty. Additionally, Gen Z’s strong commitment to social justice motivates them to not only expect accountability from companies but to actively demand meaningful change in the company’s behavior when issues arise, as stated by Seemiller & Grace

(2017). This was reflected in the findings, as participants emphasized that a sincere apology is not enough for them; they also expect concrete actions to address the problem and prevent similar mistakes in the future. The action of companies striving for change fosters a sense of authenticity that is crucial for the participants, as it signals that the brand is genuinely committed to learning from its mistakes rather than simply managing its public image.

Furthermore, this aligns with Costa and Azevedo's (2023) point that cancellation is rarely intended to completely remove or ruin an individual or brand, but rather to see a change and demand accountability. An apology that is perceived as genuine and sincere by the recipient can decrease the likelihood of cancellation as well as enhance loyalty toward the brand. This was further reflected in the empirical findings, where several participants emphasized that how a company addresses a mistake, such as offering the public a genuine apology, making a meaningful change, and taking responsibility for the actions, is more important than the mistake itself. Additionally, the expression of moral outrage, as noted by Brady et al. (2021), often serves the purpose of minimizing future violations and promoting broader social justice. This was evident among the Gen Z participants, who placed strong emphasis on the importance of a sincere apology as a step toward accountability. Therefore, when discussing company responsibility and accountability, a clear concept among the participants was the perception of authenticity, and whether the company's actions were seen as genuine or not.

Additionally, company responsibility and accountability concerning large companies like H&M and Balenciaga were topics of discussion that occurred during the interviews. Several participants expressed heightened expectations for larger companies, emphasizing that their expansive reach demands greater caution and reflection before making decisions, especially given that such companies typically involve multiple layers of approval processes. This insight aligns closely with Kucuk's (2019) and Costa and Azevedo's (2023) research, which suggests that the stronger the relationship and trust between consumers and a brand, the more intense the criticism and likelihood of engaging in anti-brand behaviors. Conversely, brands that are not held to similarly high standards may face less severe backlash, as consumer expectations toward them are generally lower. These findings emphasize how consumer expectations may significantly shape the intensity of backlash for companies facing controversies, with larger and more trusted brands facing more intense criticism due to the higher expectations and thus, a greater sense of perceived betrayal.

4.8 Structural Issue vs Honest Mistake

Building on the theme of company accountability, another idea emerged from the codes: did the scandal originate from a structural issue or an honest mistake by the company? Participant 1 did not think that (referring to the H&M scandal) the intention was for the company to make headlines, leading Participant 1 to acknowledge that the scandal emerged from an honest mistake.

“The person that chose this hoodie on this kid. No matter if they thought about it or not, like, I don’t think the intention was for it to make headlines, I think it was just an honest mistake”

- Participant 1

“I would also say that it depends on if it is systematic or like just a thing” - **Participant 11**

A systemic issue, something rooted in the brand’s structure or culture and developing over time, tends to generate less leniency from consumers if, or when, the scandal surfaces. Participant 3 noted that when multiple people are involved in planning a campaign and it appears more systematic, the criticism takes on a different tone. Expanding on this, Participant 4 pointed out that when the issue has lasted for a long period and the company or individual may have been aware of it, it feels more serious to the consumer.

“Differing then from Balenciaga where a whole production, like, there are several people involved in this, and it goes through several steps and so on. And then the critique becomes very different.” - **Participant 3**

“With Djerf Avenue it feels more like this is something that has been going on for a long time and is pretty thought out and so on, that you are aware that you are a bad boss, and I think that is worse than an honest mistake.” - **Participant 4**

4.8.1 Analysis of Structural Issue vs Honest Mistake

By distinguishing between corporate wrongdoings perceived as an honest mistake versus a structural or intentional issue, participants demonstrated greater leniency toward brands whose harmful actions appeared unintentional. Although participants generally spoke from a broader societal perspective rather than their own personal views, their responses align with the conceptual boundaries of moral outrage outlined by Abbasi et al. (2024). According to their

framework, moral outrage is typically triggered when an actor is perceived to have intentionally caused harm and violated moral norms. When participants viewed certain companies' actions as unintended or accidental, these cases did not fully satisfy the criteria for moral outrage.

Conversely, companies perceived to have acted with deliberate intent might be seen as more likely to provoke moral outrage, assuming other conditions of the framework were met. Nevertheless, all three companies discussed in the focus groups had already faced public backlash in response to their perceived misconduct. This indicates that even when observers (such as the participants) do not attribute intentional harm to a company, public backlash may still occur. This raises the possibility that moral outrage can be directed at actors not necessarily perceived as malicious, especially when there is a broader expectation that such actors should have foreseen the consequences of their actions. As such, these findings suggest a potential refinement to Abbassi et al.'s (2024) model: that moral outrage may also be triggered by perceived negligence or failure to act responsibly, even in the absence of intent to harm.

The extended version of the theoretical framework, which connects the findings with the literature review concepts of cancel culture, brand hate, moral outrage, and social media, is illustrated in Figure 2: Refined theoretical framework.

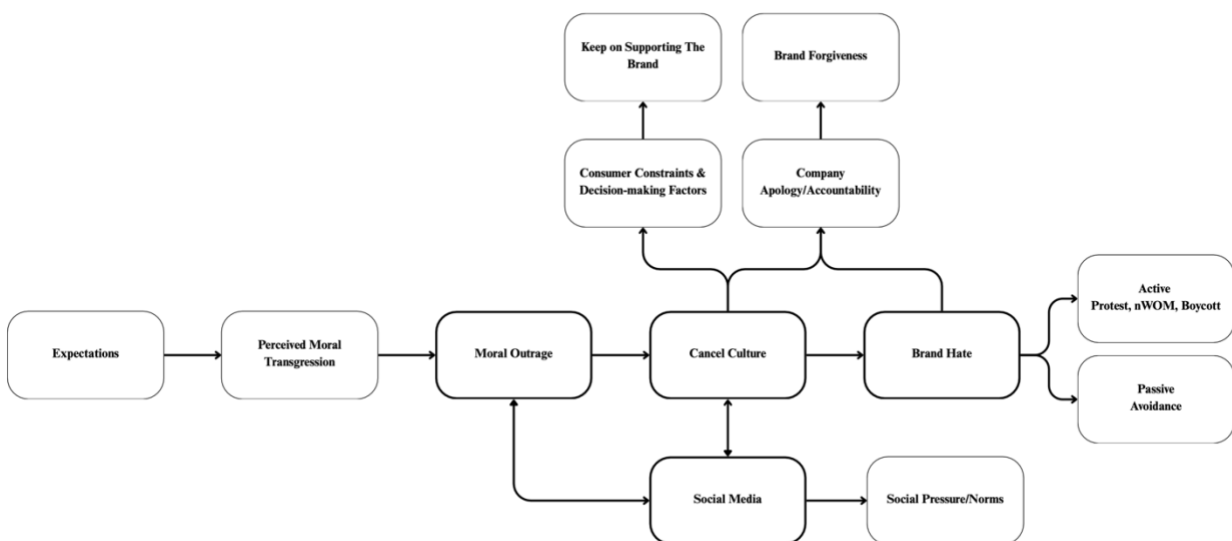


Figure 2: Refined theoretical framework (Source: The author's own work)

5. Discussion

This chapter presents an in-depth discussion of the results obtained from the empirical study, focusing on the key elements that influence how Gen Z consumers interpret cancel culture and express moral outrage. The discussion includes the exploration of the underlying factors influencing cancel culture, including social influence, consumer constraints, decision-making factors, and differences between online and offline communication. Finally, the chapter outlines the theoretical contributions and practical implications of the findings.

Each theme found in the empirical findings, together with the existing literature, was combined to answer the research question, “*How does moral outrage influence the dynamics of cancel culture?*”. The themes and empirical findings support the existing literature, although further factors were found to explain the borrowed concept of moral outrage’s influence in the dynamics of cancel culture. It involves factors such as shame and social pressure, as well as multiple trade-offs; morally, psychologically, and economically. The corresponding strategies depend not only on the severity of the scandal or the perceived moral transgressions of the corporate wrongdoing, but also on complicating factors such as budget constraints, moral compass, and cost-of-switching. This element suggests that while there may be a perceived moral transgression, it may not always lead to action. Instead, it is shaped by each person’s values, how much moral compromise they are willing to accept, and the perceived cost of switching to another brand. This distinction helps explain why some scandals result in widespread and sustained backlash for the brands, while others do not, despite similar levels of corporate wrongdoing. In light of the identified research gap in this study, the emotional response of moral outrage creates the potential for action, but whether people act upon it and how individual behaviors are influenced depends on a complex interplay of emotional, practical, and ethical factors. In this way, moral outrage influences the dynamic of cancel culture not just as a moral or emotional reaction, but as part of a broader decision-making process that is shaped by individual contexts.

Furthermore, witnessing more severe strategies than those personally employed leads participants to view others as more engaged and enlightened, while they prefer to quietly stop purchasing from the brand. This visibility fosters a perceived moral hierarchy, as online platforms amplify moral norms and portray others as more committed, despite quieter forms of

resistance. While Zarantonello et al. (2016) suggest responses to corporate wrongdoing often involve attack, a form of active brand hate, the participants challenge this, preferring avoidance strategies if they act at all. This suggests moral outrage can be internalized and expressed privately, rather than through active brand hate. Online amplification of extreme responses creates a performative moral environment, pressuring individuals to conform to dominant expressions of outrage and making quieter actions feel less legitimate, despite moral motivation. Thus, cancel culture dynamics are influenced not only by moral outrage but also by tensions between internal values and external social expectations online.

The empirical findings suggest that the manifestation of moral outrage may not always originate from individuals' convictions. Rather, its expression appears to be strongly influenced by the need to conform to the moral norms endorsed by the social group, a tendency to "follow the herd". Participants perceived expressions of moral outrage online as more extreme than offline, aligning with Crockett's (2017) observation that the digital environment lowers the risk of retaliation, making it easier to express negative emotions online than offline. These findings also fill the gap presented by Crockett (2017) by showing that moral outrage is often expressed to conform with social behaviors rather than drive ethical change. This firsthand experience of the participants offers new insights into the harsh online environment and contributes to a deeper discussion of the process of creation and establishment of moral norms. Specifically, it raises critical questions about who determines what is considered moral or immoral, and thereby also who assumes responsibility for enforcing these standards within society. The participants indicate that they rarely feel the need to speak up to enforce moral norms, despite recognizing moral violations. Instead, they often express outrage to avoid shame or being criticized for failing to conform to the group identity. This indicates that the authority to define and enforce moral standards may rest with a relatively small segment of the population. In this way, moral outrage influences the dynamic of cancel culture by shaping how people act based on what they believe others expect from them, contributing to a cycle where following the group is encouraged and opposing views are discouraged.

This thesis makes a theoretical contribution by expanding the existing marketing literature and adds to existing theories concerning social identity, brand management, and consumer behavior with the introduction of the borrowed concept of moral outrage from sociological literature. As this concept has not been deeply explored together with the phenomenon of cancel culture, the thesis addresses the theoretical gap in marketing and demonstrates that moral outrage

influences the cancel culture dynamics. These insights offer valuable contributions to existing theory by further expanding it through the integration of several theoretical frameworks to provide a more comprehensive explanation of the relationship. This offers practical implications for brands and organizations, especially those targeting Gen Z. By integrating consumer perspectives with established theories, this study contributes both to academic discourse and to strategic understanding for practitioners navigating the complexities of brand reputation in the age of cancel culture.

6. Conclusion

This chapter summarizes the research on what role moral outrage plays in cancel culture, in a study of Gen Z, drawing connections to the study's research gap, purpose, and research question. Additionally, limitations of the performed study are discussed, as well as proposed directions for future research are provided.

6.1 Conclusion

The purpose of this study was to examine how moral outrage influences the dynamics of cancel culture. The research was conducted qualitatively through focus groups with members of Gen Z, capturing both individual and collective viewpoints. This method facilitated rich discussions around the moral and emotional drivers of moral outrage and cancel culture. The data were thematically analysed to uncover key dimensions relevant to the research question: “*How does moral outrage influence the dynamics of cancel culture?*” The findings were then cross-referenced with existing literature, not only to contextualize them within established frameworks and concepts, but also to propose refinements to these models, contributing to a more nuanced understanding of moral outrage in the digital age and in relation to cancel culture.

The study suggests that moral outrage in cancel culture is shaped by several interrelated factors, including social influence, moral alignment, and the impact of being exposed to others' opinions online. It also highlights the contextual and, at times, performative nature of outrage, where public expression may not always reflect deeply held beliefs. These insights help bridge the gap in current literature by providing a consumer-focused lens on the emotional and moral mechanisms that influence the dynamics of cancel culture. Moreover, the study emphasizes

how moral values, and consequently the triggers of outrage, are shaped and amplified by social media environments.

6.2 Future Research & Limitations

When conducting a qualitative study, certain limitations must be acknowledged. Firstly, all focus group interviews were conducted in Swedish and subsequently transcribed using Microsoft Teams' transcription tool. As a result, it was necessary to translate direct quotes from the findings into English. This can constitute a limitation as some expressions and words may lose meaning in the translation between two languages, despite the significant thought and work placed into the translation process.

Furthermore, as authors, our interpretation of what constitutes moral or immoral behavior may have been influenced by our own cultural and personal values, introducing the possibility of unconscious bias. This personal interpretation could unconsciously have shaped both the design of the interview questions and the analysis of the data, constituting a limitation.

Additionally, the authors recognize that the rapid change in social media platforms and the evolving nature of online behavior may result in the findings being time-bound, as public perceptions and responses to corporate wrongdoings can shift in a short period of time. Therefore, particular attention must be paid to the timeliness and relevance of sources related to social media. This limitation highlights the need for future research to continuously track trends and changes in consumer behavior, moral outrage, and cancel culture.

Furthermore, the sample in this study was limited to a specific demographic, Gen Z, which may not fully represent the broader population's view on cancel culture. While this provides valuable experiences and perspectives of this age group, the findings may not be fully generalized to other age groups, especially given Gen Z's unique upbringing with technology and social media. To gain a broader perspective on this topic, future research could incorporate and compare other generations to explore whether the expression of moral outrage and participation in cancel culture differ across age groups. Additionally, future research could explore the emergence and various dimensions of moral outrage in greater depth, both among Gen Z and across other generations.

Lastly, our findings raise important observations concerning the question of who holds the power to define what is considered moral or immoral within society, as well as who is responsible for enforcing these moral standards. Given its complexity and relevance, this subject presents a valuable opportunity for future research to explore how moral standards are constructed and sustained within society.

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8. Appendix

Appendix A: Questions for Focus Groups 1 & 2

1. What is your initial impression of the videos we just watched? / *Vilket är det första intrycket av videosen vi precis visade?*
 - Apart from the apologies? / *Bortsett från ursäkterna?*
2. What is the probability that you would act or react in a negative way towards a company if they act like the examples? / *Hur sannolikt är det att du själv skulle agera eller reagera negativt ifall ett företag agerar som exemplen?*
3. What is morally right or wrong for a company to act? / *Vad är moralisk rätt eller fel för ett företag att agera?*
4. Where do you see people express their moral values? / *Var ser ni folk uttrycka sina moraliska värderingar?*
5. How do you think social media affect the expression of moral values? / *Hur tror ni sociala medier påverkar uttrycket av moraliska värderingar?*
6. How do you think the moral values is affected by social media? / *Hur tror ni uttrycket av moraliska värderingar påverkas av sociala medier?*

Appendix B: GDPR Form



JÖNKÖPING UNIVERSITY
Jönköping International
Business School

GDPR Thesis Study Consent Form

Required by European Union General Data Protection Regulation 2016/679

GDPR Consent for *"The role of Moral Outrage in Cancel Culture – A study among Gen Z"*

Please tick the appropriate boxes

Yes No

Taking part in the study

I consent to JIBS processing my personal data in accordance with current data protection legislation and the data delivered.

☐ ☐

I consent voluntarily to be a participant in this study and understand that I can refuse to answer questions and I can withdraw from the study at any time, without having to give a reason.

☐ ☐

My signature below indicates that I choose to take part in the thesis study and consent to JIBS treating my personal data in accordance with current data protection legislation and the data delivered.

Name of participant [IN CAPITALS]

Signature

Date

Thesis contact details for further information

Emma Nyquist
+46725881881
nyem220q@student.ju.se

Version: January 2020

Participant Information Sheet template

You are being invited to take part in a thesis study. Before you decide whether or not to take part, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully.

What is the purpose of the study collecting personal data?

This thesis is being conducted as part of the bachelor's program in Business Administration at Jönköping University and is expected to last during spring 2025. The purpose of the study is to explore how generation Z individuals respond to social and ethical issues, specifically focusing on how moral outrage influences their reactions. The data collected from the focus group will help us better understand the behaviours of this generation in the field of this topics. Your participation will contribute to improving the research methodology and enhancing student learning, particularly in data collection and analysis.

It is entirely up to you to decide whether or not to take part. If you decide to do so, you will be given this information sheet to keep and will be asked to give your consent. All the information that we collect about you during the course of the research will be kept strictly confidential. You will not be able to be identified in any ensuing reports or publications.

Under GDPR you have the following rights over your personal data:

- **The right to be informed.** You must be informed if your personal data is being used.
- **The right of access.** You can ask for a copy of your data by making a 'subject access request'.
- **The right to rectification.** You can ask for your data held to be corrected.
- **The right to erasure.** You can ask for your data to be deleted.
- **The right to restrict processing.** You can limit the way an organisation uses your personal data if you are concerned about the accuracy of the data or how it is being used.
- **The right to data portability.** You have the right to get your personal data from an organisation in a way that is accessible and machine-readable. You also have the right to ask an organisation to transfer your data to another organisation.
- **The right to object.** You have the right to object to the use of your personal data in some circumstances. You have an absolute right to object to an organisation using your data for direct marketing.
- **How your data is processed using automated decision making and profiling.** You have the right not to be subject to a decision that is based solely on automated processing if the decision affects your legal rights or other equally important matters; to understand the reasons behind decisions made about you by automated processing and the possible consequences of the decisions, and to object to profiling in certain situations, including for direct marketing purposes.

You should also know that you may contact the data protection officer if you are unhappy about the way your data or your participation in this study are being treated at dpo@ju.se

Thank you for reading this information sheet and for considering whether to take part in this research study.'

Contact details for further information

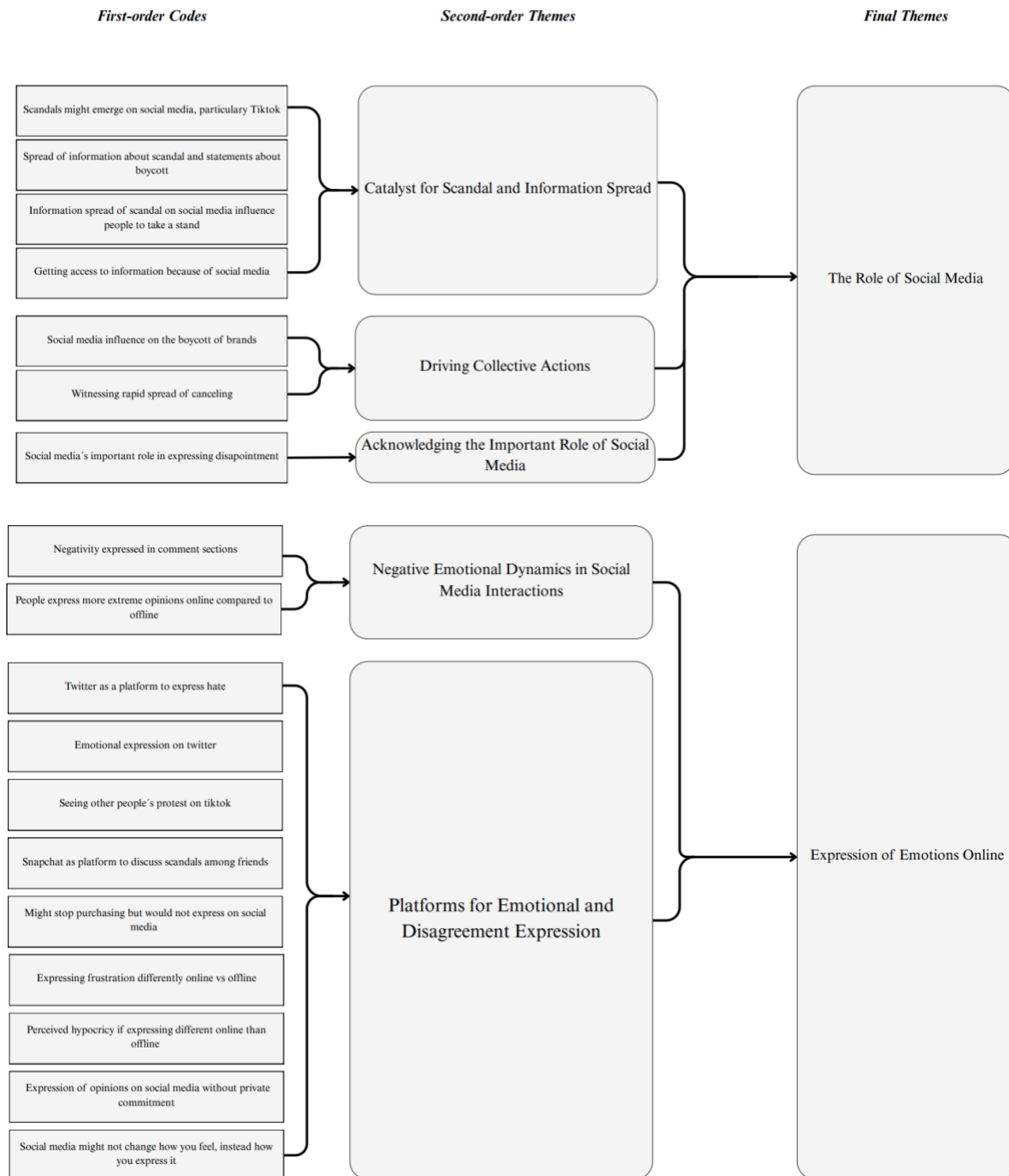
Thesis supervisor Luigi Servadio **E-mail** luigi.servadio@ju.se

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Appendix C: Thematic Analysis Process







Appendix D: Declaration

DECLARATION

We hereby declare that this thesis represents our own work.

We declare that we have obtained the necessary ethical approval (e.g., GDPR) and acknowledged our obligations and the rights of the participants in the research.

We have read and applied the Jönköping University's current research ethics guidelines with regards to the use of artificial intelligence (AI) tools in this work as presented in the Course Guide. During the preparation of this work, the authors used the following AI tools and their purpose.

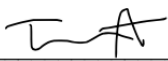
ChatGPT4 / ChatGPT4o: This AI tool was used to assist in simplifying certain paragraphs and concepts in order to ensure the authors' initial understanding. Further, it was used to improve and refine grammar and reduce the risk of simple mistakes. Finally, it assisted in the translation of the coding process. However, it should be clarified that such grammar corrections and translations were manually implemented by the authors and never purely copied, ensuring the authors' integrity and originality.

Teams: Microsoft Teams' AI-powered transcription tool was used to capture participants' expressions during meetings; however, the transcripts were then proofread and verified against the recordings by the authors.

Grammarly: To enhance academic grammar, this tool provided continuous support through the writing process by correcting minor errors, including misspellings and missing punctuation.

As authors, we have reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the thesis.

Signature:  Date: 22/5-2025

Signature:  Date: 22/5-2025

Signature:  Date: 22/5-2025